

Le rejoiced, following [that conversation] went to Lo[yang] to resist [Liu] Yao, and captured him alive. (Jin shu 95: 2486).⁶

The Jie poem from this passage is: 秀支替戾岡，僕谷劬秃當。 Its Chinese word-to-word translation is: 秀支，軍也。替戾岡，出也。僕谷，劉曜胡位也。劬秃當，捉也 that can be rendered into English along with the appropriate transcription, based on Baxter-Starostin reconstruction like the following:

秀支 = *s(l)u(s)-ke, “army” or “armies” (there is no indication of plural or singular in Chinese). Consonants in parentheses in this word and the following one existed in Early Old Chinese (7th c. B.C.) but are likely to be gone by the time of Late Old Chinese of Jin dynasty one thousand years later.

替戾岡 = *thijʔ-re(ts)-kang, “goes out” or “go out”. Possibly also “went out” or “will go out.”

僕谷 = *bok-kok, barbaric title of Liu Yao.

劬秃當 = *Ko-thok-tang, “captures”, “will capture”, or “captured.”

Let us first see how our predecessors dealt with with this poem. G. J. Ramstedt uses mostly the modern Mandarin readings of the characters above and reads: Siuk'i t'ilikang, puh-koh kü-tu-tang (Ramstedt 1922: 31).⁷ The only obvious non-Mandarin readings Ramstedt employs are /k'i/ for 支 instead of Mandarin /zhi1/, and /kü/ for 劬 instead of Mandarin /qu2/. Ramstedt's source of these archaic-looking readings is unclear: in any case none of them can pretend to be a true reconstruction: while consonantism is correct, vocalism is wrong. Ramstedt further interprets this poem as “Wenn man in den Krieg auszieht, so kann man Liu-yao gefangen nehmen.” The first thing that attracts our attention here is that Ramstedt's translation has too many words compared to original: there is no indication of impersonal (“man”) anywhere in the original, nor there is any hint at modality (“kann”), or temporal link between two clauses (“wenn”). Second, the word for “army”

⁶ Translation of the passage is mine (– A.V.).

⁷ Ramstedt's interpretation practically repeats the interpretation of Shiratori (1900: 11–12).